



The Art of Ridge Decorations in Chen Clan Ancestral Hall: A Cultural Perspective

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The background image shows the Chen Clan Ancestral Hall, a traditional Chinese building with a highly ornate, multi-tiered roof. The roof is decorated with numerous colorful sculptures of mythical creatures, including dragons and phoenixes. The building's facade features intricate carvings and a large, framed mural depicting a scene with several figures. The sky above is bright blue with scattered white clouds. A semi-transparent white rectangular overlay is positioned in the center of the image, containing the title text.

Introduction to Chen Clan Ancestral Hall

Introduction

- **Location:** Guangzhou
- **History:**
 - Built in 1894 during the Late Qing Dynasty
 - Renamed to "shuyuan" (書院)
 - Mainly used for rituals
 - Now functioning as the Guangdong Folk Art Museum
- **Decoration arts:**
 - Carvings: brick, wood, and stone
 - **Sculptures:** pottery and plaster
 - Copper and iron casting, paintings etc.



Figure 1. Aerial photo of Chen Clan Ancestral Hall.
Source: <http://www.csdzc.org/1743.html>.

Introduction

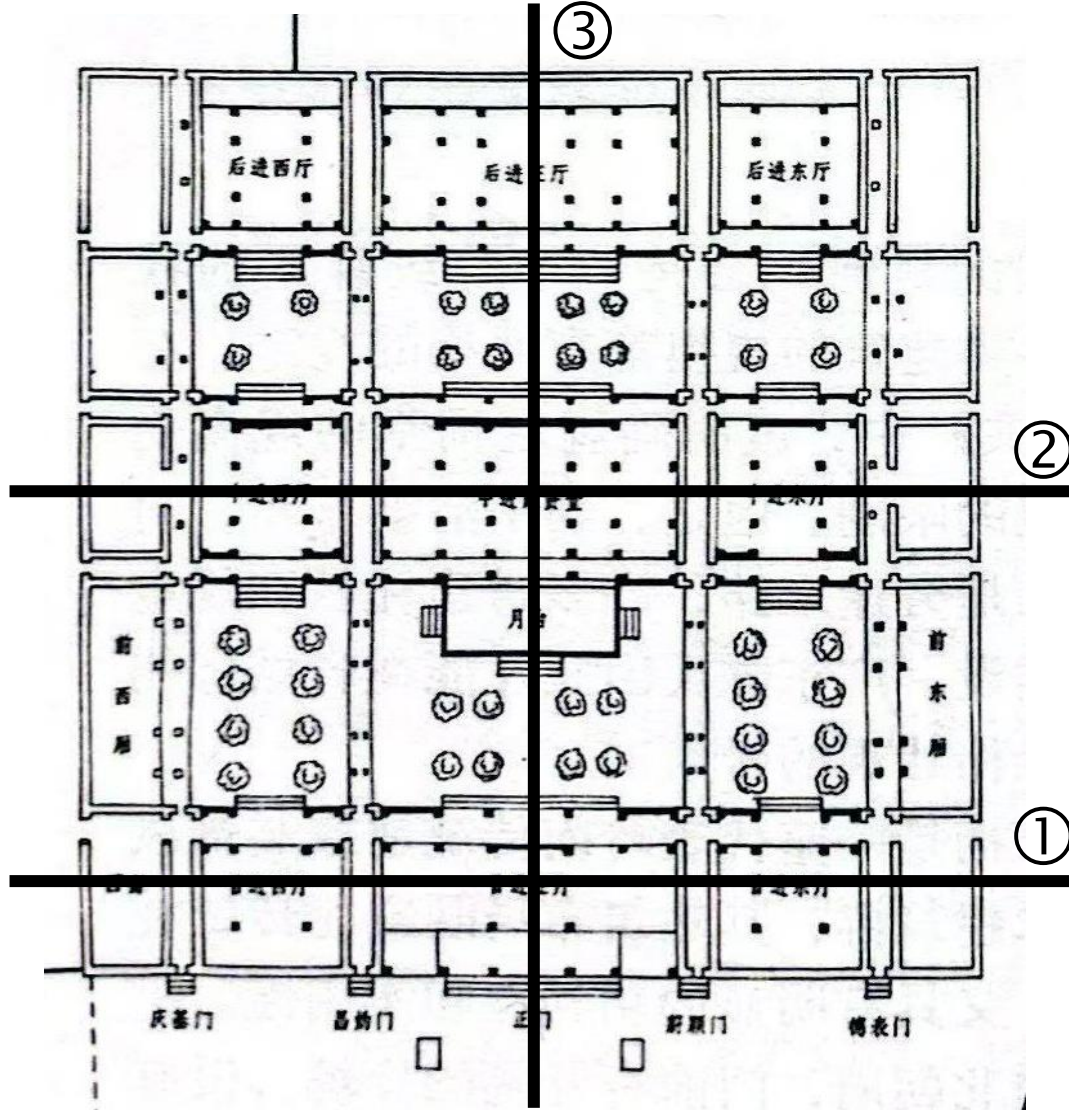


Figure 2. Plan of Chen Clan Ancestral Hall.

Source: 黄淼章. (2006). 陈家祠(第1版.). 广东人民出版社.

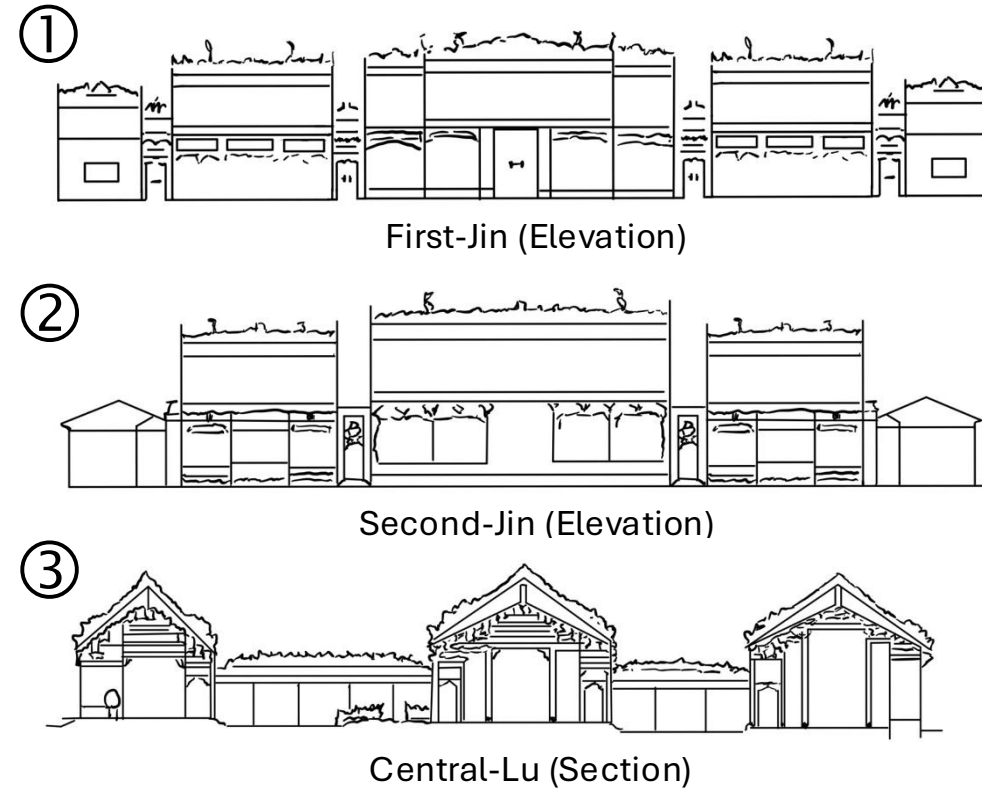


Figure 3. Elevation and section. Self-drawn.

- **Arrangement:**

- Three Jin's and Five Lu's (symmetric)
- Five modular bays for the Central Lu and three for others
- High main halls and low wing houses

- **Functionality:**

- Main halls: rituals
- Wing houses: temporary residence



Structure of Ridge Decorations

Structure

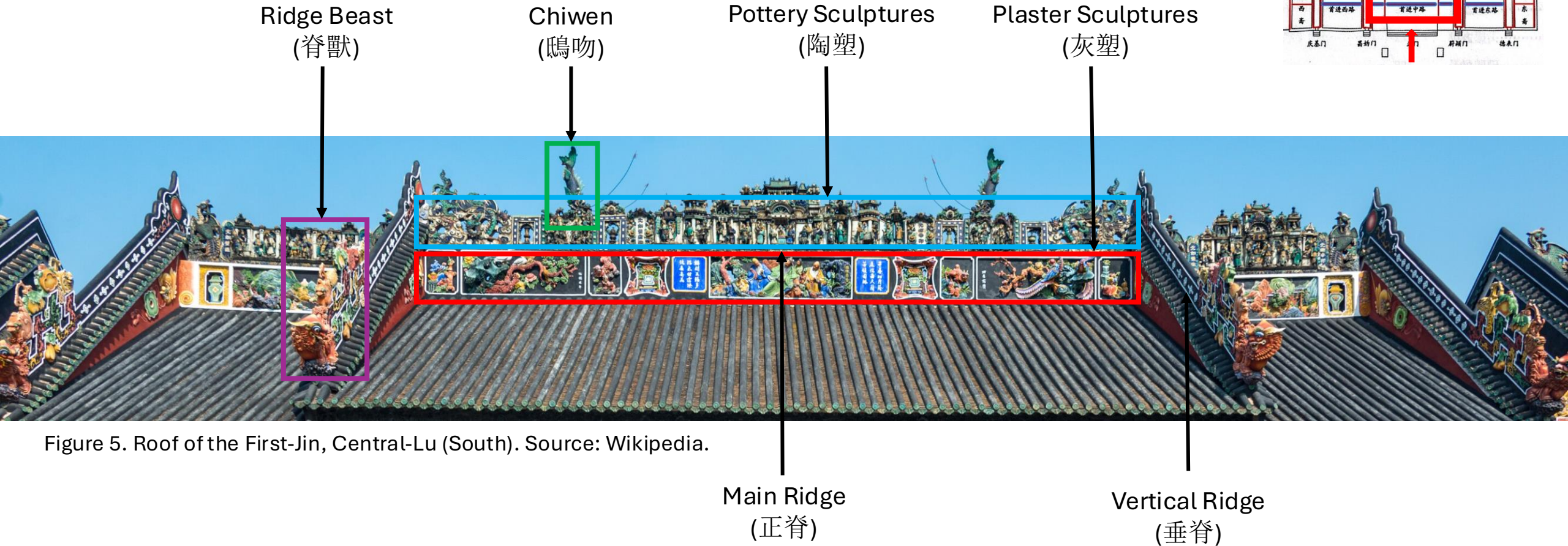


Figure 5. Roof of the First-Jin, Central-Lu (South). Source: Wikipedia.

- **Pottery sculptures** : Made of **clay** and color glaze under high temperature calcination
- **Plaster sculptures**: Using **lime** and **straw** as the raw materials, directly painted with colors

Structure



Figure 5. Roof of the First-Jin, Central-Lu (South). Source: Wikipedia.

- **Thick and multiple layers:**
 - Arrangement: plaster and pottery in the lower and upper layer, respectively
 - Functionality: decoration + preventing leakage
- **Hollowed structure:**
 - Outside: creating visual contrast + protecting against typhoons
 - Inside: reducing the weight of the ridge
- **Obliques figures:** providing the optimal elevation angle

Aesthetically pleasing and adapted to the windy and rainy weather of Lingnan



Layout of Ridge Decorations

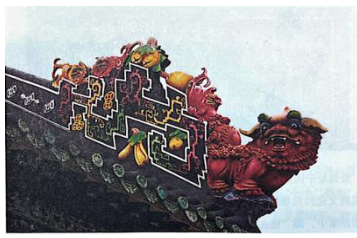
Layout

In total, 11 pottery and 57 plaster sculptures

Main ridge :
pottery
and plaster



Vertical ridge, corridor, and penthouse:
plaster only



Wing house:
none



Decrease in **decoration complexity**



Decrease in **spatial hierarchy**

The reflection of "Li" and Hierarchy

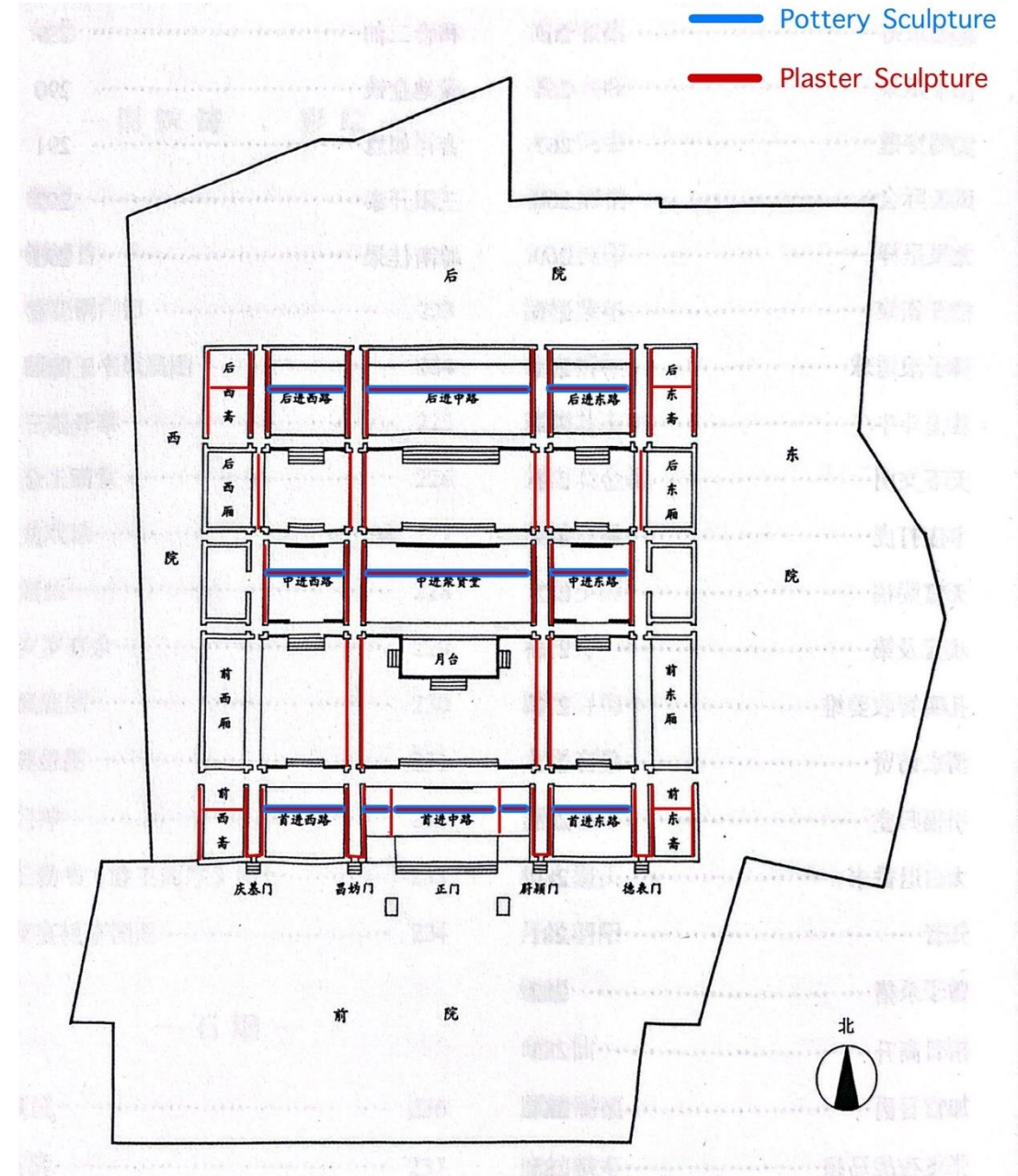


Figure 4. The distribution of ridge decorations. Self-drawn



Symbolic Meanings and Inference of Ridge Decorations

- a. Content Differences between Pottery Sculptures and Plaster Sculptures
- b. Inference of the Function of Chen Clan Ancestral Hall
- c. Characteristics of Sculptures on Connecting Corridors
- d. Symmetry in Ridge Decorations

a. Content Differences between Pottery Sculptures and Plaster Sculptures

Pottery Sculpture

More varied

- Storytelling
- Narration
- Symbolic

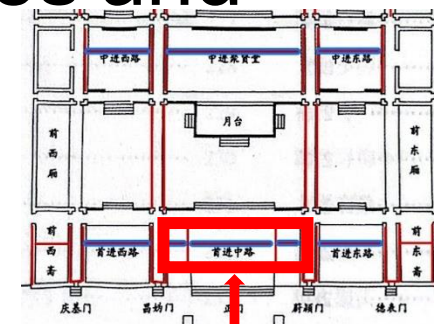
Plaster Sculpture

More plain

- Symbolic

a. Content Differences between Pottery Sculptures and Plaster Sculptures

• First-Jin Central-Lu South



Liu Lang Blame Son
六郎罪子



Pomegranate
榴开百子



Name of Workshop
文如璧店造



Year of Construction
光绪辛卯年 (1891)



Chinese Rose Kettle
四季平安



Si Lang Visit Mother
四郎探母



Fairy Kettle
仙壶集庆



Pine and Crane
松鹤延年



Fortune, Luck and Longevity
福禄寿



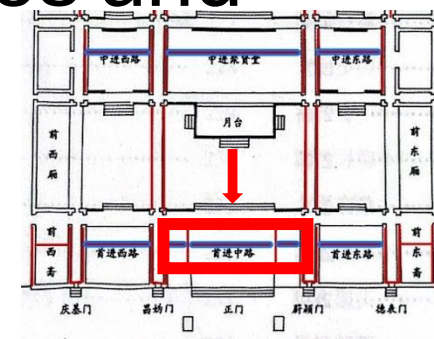
Crowing Cock and Peony
功名富贵



Fairy Kettle
仙壶集庆

a. Content Differences between Pottery Sculptures and Plaster Sculptures

- First-Jin Central-Lu North



Wang Xizhi Switched for
the Goose
王羲之换鹅



Four Intelligent Persons
in Mount Shang
商山四皓



Pine and Crane
松鹤延年



Liu Hai Played Gold Toad
刘海戏金蟾



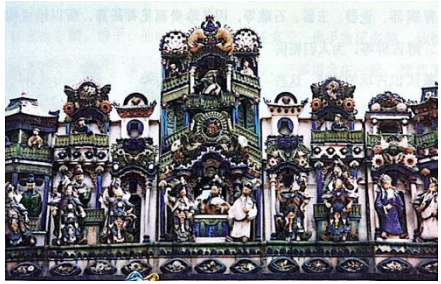
Swallow, Magpie, Peach
Blossom, and Willow
燕喜同春



Oriole and Grapes
金衣百子

a. Content Differences between Pottery Sculptures and Plaster Sculptures (Central Lu's)

- Second-Jin Central-Lu South



Guo Ziyi Promotion
卸甲封王



Melon and Butterfly
瓜瓞连绵



Vine and Cucurbit
子孙万代
福禄久长



Narcissus, Bamboo, and Rock
群仙祝寿



Longevity God and Bat
福寿双全



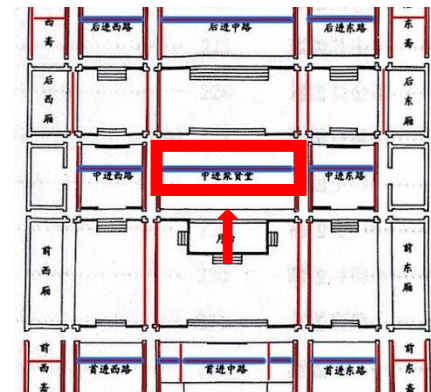
Kirin Delivered Son
麒麟送子



Union of the Nation
一子定乾坤



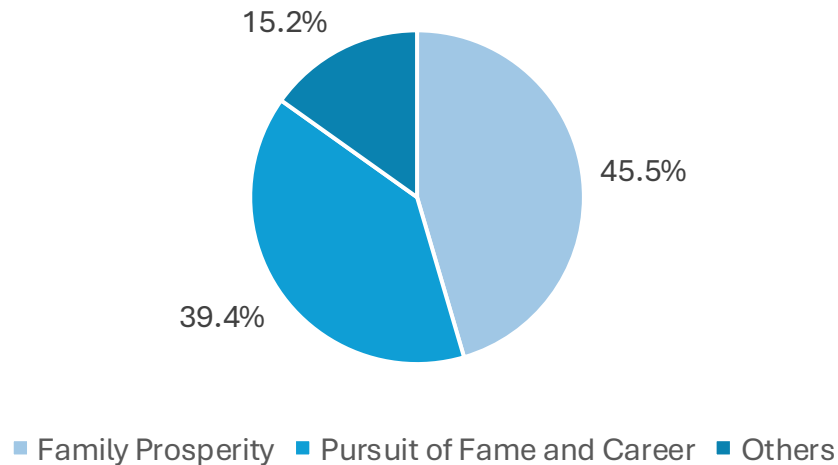
Chrysolophus, Plum Blossom, Magpie, and Peony
花魁独占



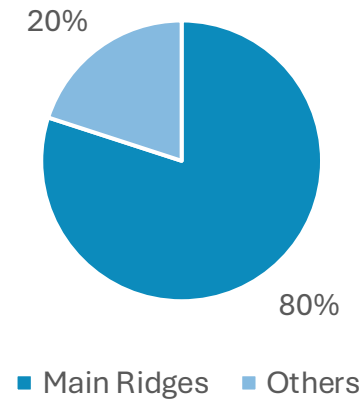
b. Inference of the Function of Chen Clan Ancestral Hall

We collected the symbolic meanings of 99 significant sculptures in total.

Symbolic Meanings of Sculptures



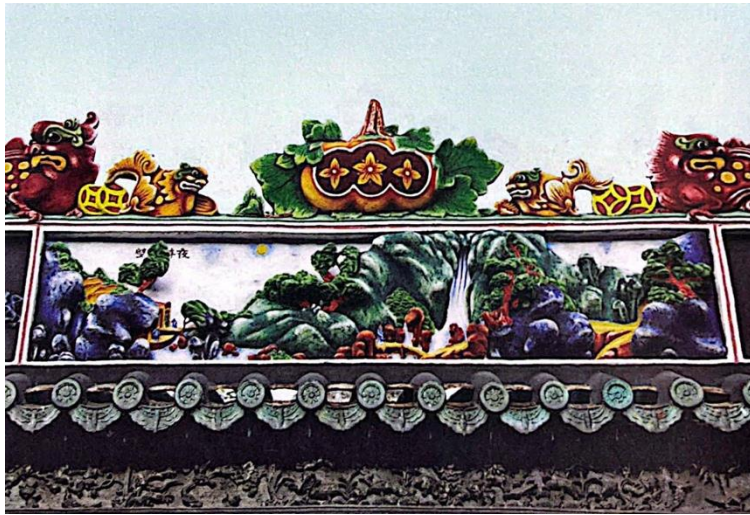
Distribution of Family Prosperity Sculptures



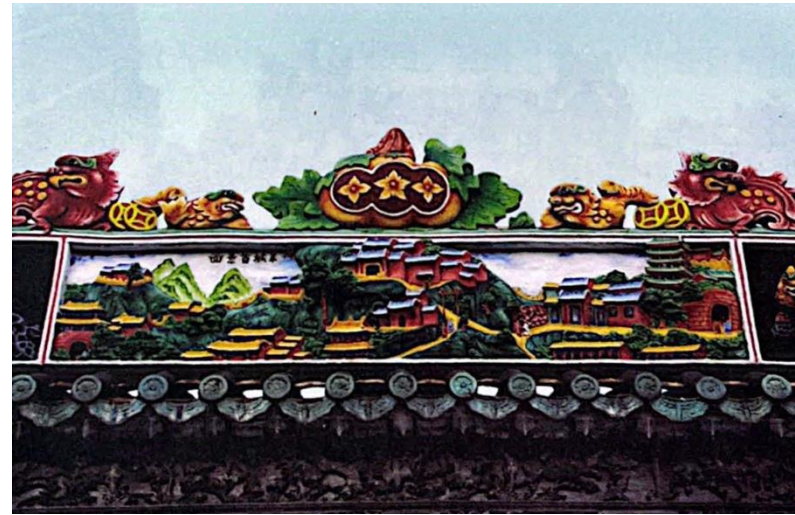
Sculptures focus on the theme of family prosperity, with less emphasize the pursuit of fame and career, confirming that the main function of the Chen Clan Ancestral Hall was worship rather than study.

c. Characteristics of Sculptures on Connecting Corridors

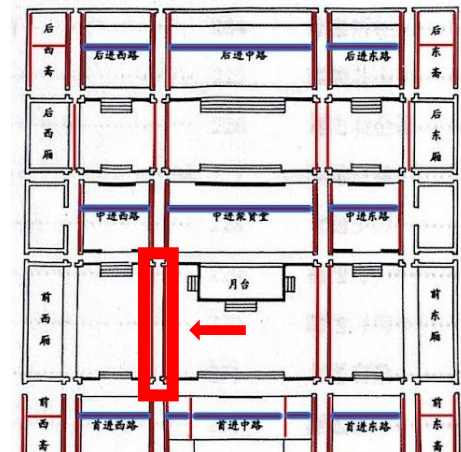
The plaster sculptures of the connecting corridors are more entertaining than ridges, resonating with the function of courtyard.



Night Tour in Chibi
夜游赤壁
First-Jin West-Lu
Corridor (East)



First View in Yang City
羊城首景
First-Jin West-Lu
Corridor (East)



c. Characteristics of Sculptures on Connecting Corridors

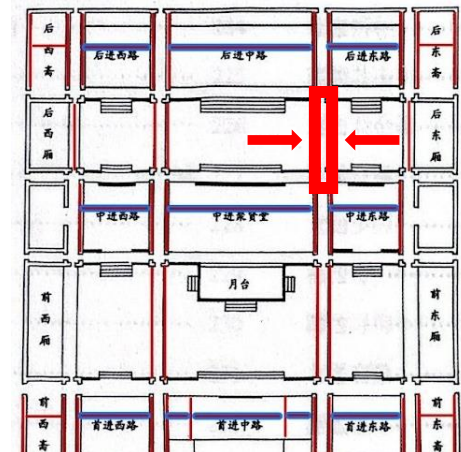
The plaster sculptures of the connecting corridors are more entertaining than ridges, resonating with the function of courtyard.



View in Pa Zhou
琶洲砥柱
Third-Jin East-Lu
Corridor (West)

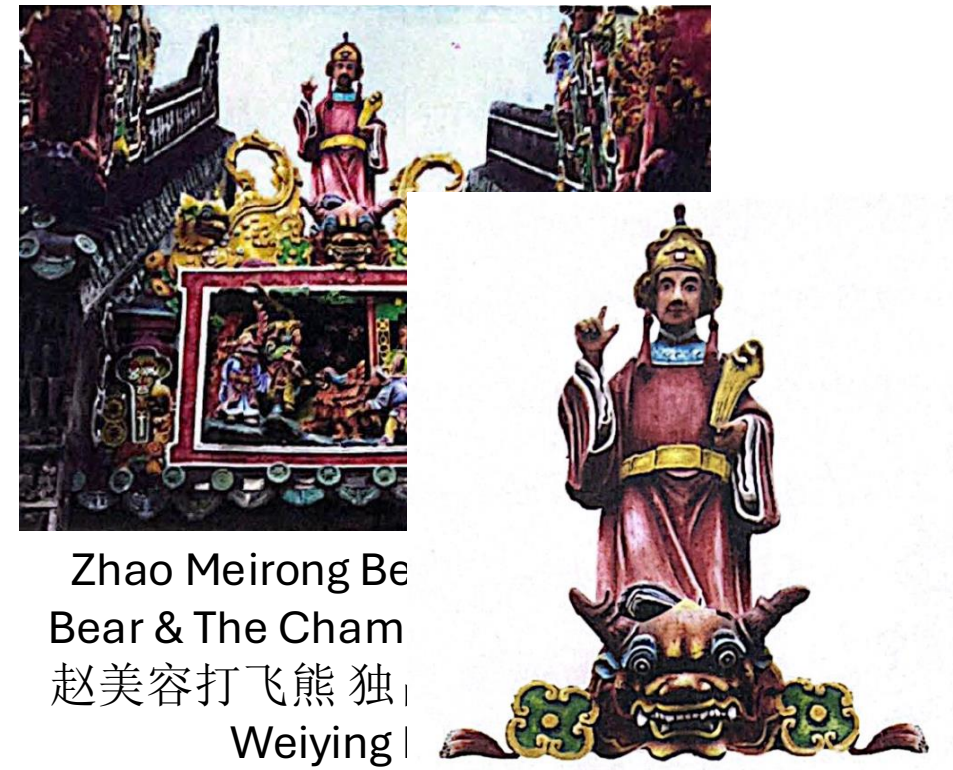
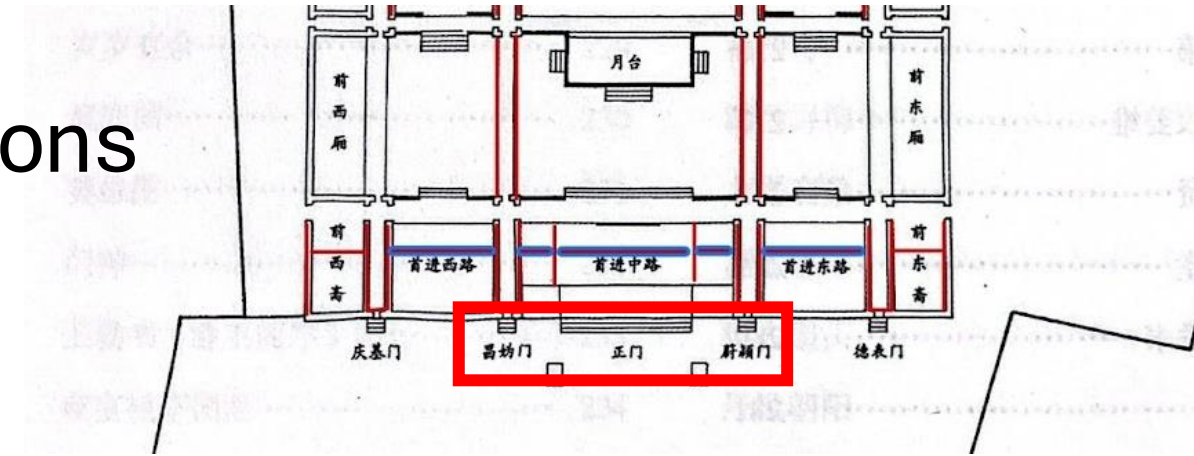


Waterfalls in Mount Xiqiao
西樵云瀑
Third-Jin East-Lu Corridor
(East)



d. Symmetry in Ridge Decorations

Clear symmetry in
Changgui Door and Weiying Door





Thank You for listening!

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